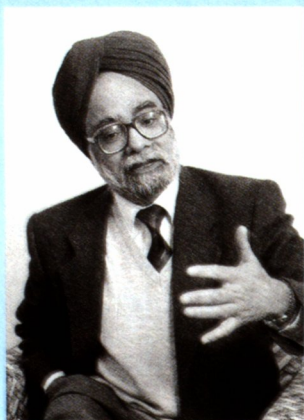


Rags to Race Course

From a powerless village in West Punjab to the power centre in Delhi, Manmohan Singh has come a long way



1932 Humble Origins

Born in a small village in West Punjab which had no water or electricity. From cycling to a nearby school, he went on to top Panjab University in Economics and won a scholarship to Cambridge and later Oxford. His professional life began with a stint at the Delhi School of Economics and later spent in bureaucratic splendour as finance secretary, governor, RBI and deputy chairman, planning commission.

1991 Political Baptism

His political career began ironically with another non-Gandhi prime minister. It was P.V. Narasimha Rao who picked Manmohan as his finance minister. The duo liberalised India's economy. It was a dramatic shift away from the traditional Congress policy of a welfare state.

1999 Mixed Fortunes

Contested his first Lok Sabha from South Delhi and lost but remained the leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha at a time when Sonia became a first-time MP. Tutored her on the economy. She developed a liking for this soft-spoken



SHARAD SAXENA



HEMANT CHAWLA

erudite Congressman. He played a prominent role in getting Sitaram Kesri to step down as Congress President to ensure Sonia's ascension.

2004 Prime Ministership

Sonia nominated him as her candidate for prime minister. His Mr Clean image got a beating when

he was forced to swear "tainted" RJD ministers into his Cabinet. But Manmohan proved an adept learner of realpolitik. Later, he was forced to tamper his reformist image and give in to several populist measures such as oil price cuts and PSU disinvestment rollbacks and reservations in private

Mumbai's Nariman Point where he preaches to the PLU about the nuclear deal and economic growth. In the far off Kochi, he ridicules the communists for always being on the "wrong side of history" whether it is the Quit India movement or the Green Revolution or, of course, the nuclear deal. His campaign speeches are delivered in his trademark, measured conference room style. He could well be addressing the G-20, instead of exhorting the G-Billion—the world's largest democracy—to vote for him. "The highest demand is for Sonia and Rahul," says Dalbir Singh, Congress secretary who has been planning the party's campaign since 1991. "The prime minister is being increasingly

utilised in urban centres and selected rural towns," he says. Rahul as the star campaigner is slated to address over 300 meetings, Sonia around 145-150 while their prime ministerial candidate will do one-third this number, concentrating largely on state capitals. The masses are not for this 76-year old man, who is yet to come to terms with the craft and crassness of politics. He is more comfortable in sympathetic focus groups. Strangely, he refuses to take up the challenge from his opponent for a television debate.

While projecting Manmohan, there is also a simultaneous subliminal campaign that focuses on the dynasty. When the Congress talks about the achievements of the UPA, it